

7.2 Netiquette

Quickstudy by Brian Sullivan

Definition: Netiquette is all about etiquette on the Internet. Think of it as rules of good behavior adapted for electronic communications via e-mail, instant messaging, chat rooms and discussion forums.

1. Don't lie about who you are. In Computerworld.com's forums, one man recently took a very strong stance defending Microsoft. Other forum members accused him of working for a company that partners with Microsoft but not disclosing that fact. Members said they recognized the man's arguments and writing style from other forums. After the brouhaha, the offender apologized for causing trouble and vanished off the boards.

Vanessa DiMauro, Computerworld.com's director of communities, points out another problem with a fake identity. People form relationships in discussion groups, and you don't want to end up in a position where you have to reveal that you're not the 24-year-old roller-skating blonde you said you were.

More important, DiMauro says, such a misrepresentation of identity is simply a violation of trust, and that's never good form.

2. Know when to shut up. These days, it's hard to determine when a conversation is over, according to Joseph Cothrel, vice president of research at Participate Systems Inc. in Chicago. He says we've all been in instant messaging or e-mail conversations that just keep going on and on. Do you really have to say "You're welcome" to the guy who just said "Thank you"? Sometimes it feels like everyone is trying to out-polite one another.
3. Know when it's OK to talk. When you first show up at a discussion forum, it's not always a good idea to plunge right in, Cothrel says. Take a look around, and read the forum guide-